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california - Newsom signs bill to sustain outdoor dining - Other state politics and policy news

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SACRAMENTO >> Earlier this week, Gov. Gavin Newsom signed legislation to sustain outdoor dining across California by extending regulatory flexibility adopted during the COVID-19 pandemic. Authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D — Encino), Assembly Bill (AB) 1217 will enable continued outdoor, patio, and al fresco dining as restaurants continue to recover from the COVID-19 pandemic and navigate rising costs.

“Neighborhood restaurants are the backbone of communities across California, but many are still struggling to recover from the pandemic,” said Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel. “Outdoor dining has been a critical lifeline that has helped these beloved establishments keep their doors open during these challenging times. I am grateful to Governor Newsom for signing this bill today and look forward to working closely with him to support small businesses across California.”

“Outdoor dining has become an important lifeline for restaurants, and it’s something that we have all come to love and enjoy,” said Madelyn Alfano, Past Chair of the California Restaurant Association Board of Directors and owner of Maria’s Italian Kitchen, a neighborhood Italian restaurant with several locations in the San Fernando Valley. “Many restaurant owners have invested lots of money to build beautiful outdoor dining spaces to increase their capacity for private events and recoup some of their losses from these difficult past few years. AB 1217 will help sustain this crucial tool and allow local restaurants such as my own to continue to provide delicious meals for our communities.”

AB 1217 builds upon AB 61, which was authored by Assemblymember Gabriel and signed into law by Governor Newsom in 2021. AB 61 provided restaurants with regulatory flexibility on a number of key issues, including enabling more outdoor food preparation and service, allowing restaurants to better use their own spaces for increased outdoor dining capacity, and extending existing orders allowing for alcohol service on outdoor premises. AB 1217 extends this regulatory flexibility to July 1, 2026.

Cal State labor strife cools down

Hot labor summer at California State University is turning into temperate labor autumn as three unions representing 26,000 workers have tentatively agreed to multi-year contracts with Cal State leadership.

The deals don’t include all the labor groups, including Cal State’s largest, the faculty union which represents 29,000 workers. But they likely forestall the potential for virtually every unionized worker at Cal State to go on strike, a would-be nightmare scenario for Cal State.

The three-union deal came in stages over the past few weeks, culminating Thursday with the largest of the three, the union representing staff workers, securing 10% raises over two years and then a much-sought-after deal with CSU to put employees on salary steps. With the step plan, each worker gets a 2% raise when they move up the step ladder, securing predictability in pay that workers long sought. The deal is contingent on adequate state funding. If another Cal State union gets higher wages, the staff union can ask for additional raises.

But a labor deal between faculty and the university system appears to be far off. The California Faculty Association wants 12% raises this year plus improvements to other benefits; the system said they can do that over three years or 5% in one year. The union says 12% in one year is necessary to make up for soaring inflation. Cal State says they cannot afford it, even after approving ongoing tuition hikes starting next fall.

Both sides are in mediation, but if that doesn't result in a deal, the union is threatening to strike. In two weeks, faculty union leadership is planning to ask members to approve permission to call a strike. That doesn't mean a strike will happen, but it empowers union leadership to initiate one. Meanwhile, the union could call for a strike through a different legal process called an unfair labor practice strike.

The faculty union's leadership wouldn't comment on how Cal State's deal with three other unions affects its negotiations with the university, but Trevor Griffey, a labor scholar at UCLA, thinks if the union's membership is fired up enough, a strike could be imminent.

"A well-organized CFA could still shut the entire school system down," especially because the faculty union represents full-time and part-time educators, Griffey said. Still, "an even larger strike that included staff could be even more disruptive," he added.

Faculty are in a strong position, said Stephen McFarland, a labor scholar and a union executive team member at Cal State Dominguez Hills. Cal State's deal with three other unions is a "divide and conquer" strategy, he said.

Students know that "our teaching conditions are their learning conditions," he added.

Key dates for California next week

Monday is the deadline to file state income taxes for almost all of California. The date was delayed from April 18 for residents in 55 counties covered by federal disaster declarations due to the devastating winter storms. (Residents of Modoc and Shasta had an Aug. 15 deadline, while only people in Lassen had the normal April deadline.) The Franchise Tax Board has more information.

It's not only the last day to file returns to avoid penalties, but also to become eligible for the earned income, child and foster youth tax credits.

State Controller Malia Cohen, in a statement: "These cash-back credits can put hundreds or even thousands of dollars back in the pockets of families struggling to make ends meet."

The later tax deadline complicated the state budget, which for 2023-24 covered a $30 billion-plus deficit. In the latest revenue outlook, the nonpartisan Legislative Analyst's Office said revenues could be $9.5 billion higher than projections, but that would still mean a $10 billion deficit for 2024-25. Another caution from the LAO: "It is entirely possible that revenues could end up $15 billion higher or lower than our estimate for 2023-24 and $30 billion higher or lower for 2024-25."

Earthquakes: Thursday, the state plans to test its MyShake app, which was designed to blare a warning on phones of an earthquake moments before they're expected to hit. To test its features and to prepare users to take cover, the app will set off an alert at 10:19 a.m. More than 9 million people in California have enrolled in the drill, which will also go off on phones in Oregon and Washington. To participate, register and download the MyShake app for your iPhone or Android device.

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